

Western Marxism Final Exam

Answer Sheet

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问题 1/Question 1:

Question: *Explain commodity fetishism, as discussed in the last part of the first chapter of Capital, Volume 1. Then take a more expansive view, including discussing commodity fetishism along with other related phenomenon, either those we discussed in class or that you have encountered in other studies. How does commodity fetishism relate to Marx's critique of capitalism generally, and likewise, how does it relate conceptually to dialectical and historical materialism? Provide some examples from your everyday life to illustrate the concept.*

Answer:

Sub Question 1: *Explain commodity fetishism, as discussed in the last part of the first chapter of Capital, Volume 1.:*

Commodity fetishism is a very important idea in Marx. It means that people think commodities have magic power. People see commodity as if it is natural thing. But actually, commodity is not natural. It is made by human labor. But in capitalism, people forget this. They think price is natural, not social relation.

In Capital, Volume 1, Chapter 1, last part, Marx says: "The commodity form of the product of labor is the economic cell-form of capitalist society." He writes this sentence. He says commodity form is mystery. People see commodity as thing, but it is not thing. It is social relation. Marx says: "The social character of labor appears to the producer as a material character of the products of labor." I reckon it is crucial.

Marx explains that in capitalist society, the relation between people is hidden. People see only relation between things. For example, people see "apple costs 5 yuan" but not "this apple is made by farmer's labor." So commodity fetishism is when people worship commodity like it is god. It is false consciousness.

This is the way Marx presents it. He uses simple words but deep meaning. He says: "The mystic character of commodities is the mystic character of the social relation." This is very important. I think this is a key point.

Sub Question 2: *Then take a more expansive view, including discussing commodity fetishism along with other related phenomenon, either those we discussed in class or that you have encountered in other studies.*

Commodity fetishism is not only about commodity. It is very important for understanding capitalism. I think it is like a religion in capitalist society. People worship commodities as if they are magic things. But actually, it is not magic. It is social relation.

I want to discuss more widely. First, commodity fetishism connects to money fetishism. Money is like a special commodity. People think money is natural power. For example, when I buy coffee, I think "money is good" but not "this money comes from worker's labor." Money hides the real social relation. This is very similar to commodity fetishism.

It also connects to consumerism. Taking Starbucks as an example, some people think that Starbucks is good because of its brand. But they forget the real thing: the coffee bean is grown by farmer in poor country, and farmer gets little money. People worship the brand, not the labor. This is commodity fetishism in daily life.

I also want to discuss this in terms of my own major software engineering. For example, when I use TikTok, I think "this app is fun" but not "this app uses my data to make money." The app is a commodity. People worship the user experience, not the labor of programmers or the data exploitation. This is digital commodity fetishism. It is very new form of commodity fetishism. Also, commodity fetishism connects to false consciousness. People think capitalism is natural, not a system made by humans. Like Marx said: "People see relations between things, not relations between people."

In conclusion, commodity fetishism is everywhere: in money, in brands, in apps. It hides the real social relation. I think this is very important.

Sub Question 3: *How does commodity fetishism relate to Marx's critique of capitalism generally, and likewise, how does it relate conceptually to dialectical and historical materialism? Provide some examples from your everyday life to illustrate the concept.*

Commodity fetishism is very important for understanding Marx's general critique of capitalism, because it shows how social relationships between people are hiding behind relationships between things. Marx argues that in capitalism, people start to see commodities as if they have their own independent value and power, instead of understanding that this value comes from human labor. So the idea is that commodities look like they are natural and objective, when in fact they are created by specific historical and social relations. This misunderstanding makes capitalism appear normal and even inevitable, and this is one reason why Marx thinks capitalism is a system that hides its own contradictions.

This concept also connects directly to dialectical and historical materialism. From a dialectical materialist view, social reality is full of contradictions, but in commodity fetishism these contradictions become invisible. People see things as stable and natural instead of seeing the dynamic process of production. And from a historical materialist view, commodity fetishism shows how people forget the historical development that created capitalism in the first place. People think buying and selling is just human nature, but this is only true under certain historical conditions. So the concept is important because it connects the everyday experience of the market with the deeper material structures of society.

In my daily life, I can see examples everywhere. For example, when I buy a smartphone, I usually don't think about the workers in factories or the miners who extract minerals; the phone just feels like an object with its own value. Another example is when people pay a lot for brand-name clothes (like the Starbucks example I mentioned early) only because the brand seems to have some magical quality. In reality this "magic" is created by labor and marketing, but people don't think about that. This is exactly how commodity fetishism works.

Word Count (not including the sub questions lines) : 810

问题 2/Question 2:

Question: *We examined a case study related to the National Mall in Washington, DC, and did so using Marxism and critical geography. Recount that discussion here, including Doreen Massey's critique of "gendered space." How should we theorize the relationship between gender representations, religion, and war? How should we historicize these developments on the National Mall as the US has developed historically and internationally over the past two centuries? How should we account for the Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial in these broader discussions?*

Answer: (请在此处作答，不够可加页)

Sub Question 1: *We examined a case study related to the National Mall in Washington, DC, and did so using Marxism and critical geography. Recount that discussion here, including Doreen Massey's critique of "gendered space."*

In the class discussion, we looked at the National Mall through a Marxist and critical geography lens, and we tried to see how space is not neutral but is socially produced. We discussed how the Mall is often presented as a natural, timeless national space, but actually it is built on very specific historical and economic relations. Marxism helped us understand that the National Mall is not only a physical place but also a symbolic landscape. A landscape that certain forms of labor, power, and ideology are hidden. For example, the monuments focus on presidents, wars, and national unity, but they hide the labor of marginalized groups, enslaved people, or immigrant workers who actually built the US. We also used Doreen Massey's critique of gendered space, and she says that space is often constructed with implicit gender meanings. People can see their reflection on the monuments. They think they are watching names on the monuments, but they are actually seeing themselves. Massey argues that this kind of gendered space limits how people imagine the nation and who belongs to it. So the Mall is not just a national space but a gendered space, where women are less represented and usually connected only symbolically.

Sub Question 2: *How should we theorize the relationship between gender representations, religion, and war?*

To theorize the relationship between gender, religion, and war, I think these three elements work together to build a narrative of national identity. Gender representations often portray men as protectors and warriors, while women are shown as symbols of purity or the innocence. This creates a repeated story where men fight wars and women inspire them. Religion also enters because many monuments borrow religious symbols, like temples, crosses, or sacred language. This adds a moral meaning to war, as if war is not only political but also morally necessary.

So the relationship is dialectical: religion justifies war, war reinforces masculine ideals, and masculine ideals strengthen religious-symbolic authority. It becomes a closed circle. And this circle makes it harder to question the state's use of violence because the representations appear natural and moral. In this way, The Mall makes this relationship look very normal, even when it is historically constructed.

Sub Question 3: *How should we historicize these developments on the National Mall as the US has developed historically and internationally over the past two centuries?*

To historicize these developments, I put the Mall within the changing history of the United States. In the nineteenth century, Washington, DC was still forming its national identity, and the Mall became a way to show unity after civil war and expansion. In the twentieth century, new wars like World War II and Vietnam brought new memorials, each representing different conflicts and different political moods. The Cold War also influenced designs, because the Mall needed to show national strength and democratic power.

Internationally, the rise of the US as a global imperial power affected the way monuments were built. The growing influence of American military interventions shaped how the nation represented itself. As the US became more involved globally, the Mall's symbols also became more international or global in meaning, but still centered on American leadership.

Sub Question 4: *How should we account for the Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial in these broader discussions?*

The Martin Luther King, Jr. Memorial enters this larger discussion as a challenge and also as a contradiction. On one side, it expands the national narrative by giving space to civil rights struggles, racial justice, and a Black leader who criticized American capitalism and militarism. On the other side, the memorial sometimes reduces King's radical message. So it fits into the Mall, but also questions the Mall.

From a gendered-space perspective, King's memorial introduces a different kind of masculinity—one not based on war but on moral courage. From a Marxist view, it shows how the state can incorporate some critiques while still hiding deeper economic contradictions. And from a historical perspective, it reflects the broader development of American democracy, race relations, and international reputation in the past two centuries.

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